

Chapter

Gopika-Vallabh — The Divine Secret of Radha and Krishna



Introduction: A Leela Hidden in a Name

Shri Krishna is called **Gopika-Vallabh** — "Vallabh" means the beloved, the beloved of the gopis. In this short discourse, Acharya Upendra Ji opens up a sweet leela behind this name: the leela in which Radha and Krishna exchange their roles with each other. And in it he shows a deep principle of love.

1. Exchanging Roles

Acharya Ji explains that the Gopika and the Vallabh would sometimes exchange their roles:

"The Gopika and the Vallabh — they exchange roles. Sometimes they would say: Radha will have to live Krishna's role, and Krishna will have to live Radha's life."

And he calls this the core element of love:

"That's the essential element in love."

Love does not mean only living together; it means living each other's life and seeing it from within.

2. The Same Experiment in Today's Home

This leela is not just a story from the Puranas; Acharya Ji applies it directly to husbands and wives today:

"Just once, tell your husband: all day now, you are in the kitchen, with the children, everything else — then he will understand her pain."

And the exchange goes both ways:

"And she is supposed to live his life exactly."

Until we stand in the other person's place and look, their tiredness, their difficulties, their **pain** remain mere words to us.

3. The Pot, the Mother-in-Law and the Call of the Flute

This exchange was not a game of a single day:

"They lived like that for a month."

Now Krishna had to bear everything Radha bore every day:

"Then Krishna goes with the pot, dressed in a girl's clothes and all. Then the mother-in-law will shout — that is the leela they tell."

The same mischief Krishna used to play on the gopis now comes back to him:

"Then, deliberately, once the pot, twice — it will break. Then you have to go back to the river."

And then comes the moment when the flute plays. Acharya Ji puts it in a simple, modern metaphor:

"Today's mobile ringtone — at that time his was the flute. When she heard it, she simply had to come; if she didn't come, he would shout."

"She would say, 'How can I come? There's a problem here.'"

The call to which Krishna expected Radha to come at once — now he lived the other side of that call himself. The result:

"So once he understood how much work that woman did."

Another's difficulty is understood only when we carry their pot, walk to their river and take up their responsibilities ourselves.

4. When Radha Became the Vallabh

On the other side, Radha was now in the role of the "Vallabh" — and she too found out how hard that role is:

"Now she goes as the Vallabh. Now she has to do the work: ask after others, take this, take that — everything, you see."

"Now the one whose task it was — solve others' problems — she doesn't know how to do any of it."

Looking after everyone, solving everyone's problems — what came naturally to Krishna was just as unfamiliar to someone else. Every role has its own burden, and that burden cannot be seen from outside.

5. The Meaning of the Name "Gopika-Vallabh"

Now Acharya Ji reveals the secret of this name:

"So when we say 'Gopika-Vallabh', the role of the Gopika has been reversed, and the role of the Vallabh she has played — opposite."

And here he gives his main message about love:

"And these opposite roles are essential forces sometimes in life. Only then is love fully expressed."

Living the opposite role is an essential force in life — through it, love is expressed in its fullness.

Summary: Key Takeaways

- 1 The name **Gopika-Vallabh** holds the leela of Radha and Krishna exchanging their roles.
- 2 Living each other's life is the core of love — "the essential element in love".

- 3 If a husband handles the kitchen and the children for a day, he will understand his wife's pain; and the wife too is to live her husband's life in the same way.
- 4 Krishna lived the other side of the pot, the mother-in-law and the call of the flute — and understood how much work a woman does.
- 5 By becoming the Vallabh, Radha learned how hard it is to look after everyone and solve everyone's problems.
- 6 Opposite roles are at times an essential force in life — only then is love fully expressed.